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Talent management in academia: performance systems and HRM policies

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Talent and performance management are becoming a key strategic HRM issue for universities. This study adds to our knowledge by critically examining recruitment and selection practices for junior and senior academic talent in the Netherlands. We show that academic subfields differ in terms of how appointments are organised, how candidates are sought and identified and how performance indicators play a role in recruitment. We identify three key dilemmas in talent and performance management for universities: (a) transparency versus autonomy, (b) power of HR versus power of academics, (c) equality versus homogeneity. This article challenges the view of an academic world where the allocation of rewards and resources is governed by the normative principles of transparency and objective performance systems, and it highlights the distance between these HRM instruments and the actuality of social interaction in academic recruitment practices.
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INTRODUCTION

The ability to attract and retain top talent is rapidly becoming a key issue for human resource management at universities (Huisman *et al.*, 2002; Metcalf *et al.*, 2005; Kubler and DeLuca, 2006). Universities are certainly not the only employers competing for highly qualified employees, and a number of recent surveys suggest that academic disciplines are already suffering from a chronic shortage of talented people in some countries (Gilliot *et al.*, 2002; van Balen & van den Besselaar, 2007; Lubbe and Larsen, 2008; Edwards and Smith, 2010). The composition and quality of academic staff is vitally important for the quality of education programmes and university research, as well as the reputation and competitive position of universities and institutions in the academic community (Lorange, 2006).

Talent and performance management has therefore entered the strategic HRM agenda of many universities and is being reinforced by the trend of universities switching from a collegial to a managerial model (Deem, 2001). The use and importance of individual performance indicators, such as bibliometrics in the evaluation and recruitment of academics, has therefore increased (Tijssen *et al.*, 2002; Van Raan, 2005; Basu, 2006). Although these systems have become widespread, and have been much criticised (Parker and Jary, 1995; Nkomo, 2009; Özbilgin, 2009; Van den Brink & Benschop, forthcoming), their use and implementation in daily recruitment decisions has scarcely been investigated. How are they applied, how is academic talent recruited and what consequences does this have for fairness, equality and transparency (Husu, 2000; Gomez-Mejia *et al.*, 2009; Van den Brink *et al.*, 2010)?

The aim of this study is to provide a clearer picture on how academic talent is defined and recruited in order to obtain a better understanding of academic talent and performance management and on how that it is implemented in practice. Our study adheres to recent calls

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in the HRM literature (Holmes and McElwee, 1995; Watson, 2004, 2010; McKenna *et al*., 2010) to move away from the prescriptive, functionalist and critical tradition of HRM towards a focus on everyday HRM practices 'in order to account for the way management actually behaves in organizing work and managing people' (Watson, 2010: 917). Janssens and Steyaert (2009) encourage HRM scholars to adopt a more reflective and practice-oriented view of HRM, to examine it as a set of practices, embedded in a global, economic, political and socio-cultural context. We will therefore consider recruitment and selection as a set of social and cultural practices which have a distinctly practical nature but which are also an arena in which values are applied and conflicts between values and group identities are enacted (Bourdieu, 1988; Knights and Richards, 2003; Bozionelos, 2005). Even in the 'managerialist' university where bibliometrics are used to evaluate scholars, the recruitment and selection of academic talent is not simply a technical endeavour that involves judging which academics are the best. It is also a political endeavour that involves negotiations between multiple actors.

Current literature on talent management and performance indicators rarely pays attention to the implementation process, power processes and context (Watson, 2004; McKenna *et al*., 2010). This article fills this void by studying the recruitment and selection practices of junior and senior scholars in the Netherlands in the current transition of academic talent and performance management and, as stated previously, reflecting on three challenges HR managers face implementing performance systems in academic recruitment and selection.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Academic talent and HRM management

Most universities currently operate in a global, complex, dynamic and highly competitive environment. Trends such as globalisation, the increased mobility of academics and the retirement of the baby-boom generation are leading to a scarcity of academic talent in many disciplines (Musselin, 2005; Verhaegen, 2005; Shaikh, 2009). At the same time, universities are confronted with new public management trend of 'managerialism' (Deem, 2001; Smeenk *et al*., 2006), the introduction of private-sector management practices to public-sector institutions. The shift from a collegial to a managerial model has provoked changes in HRM strategies such as individual staff performance systems (Holmes and McElwee, 1995). The sector is moving towards a more 'professional' approach to staff management, not only in the Netherlands, but also in other Western countries (Holmes and McElwee, 1995; Lorange, 2006; Holland *et al*., 2007; Egginton, 2010). In the managerial model, the collegiality of academics of equal status working together with minimal hierarchy and maximal trust (Deem, 1998) is replaced by a seemingly more objective, fair and transparent approach to evaluating performance. Part of this movement is the emphasis on recruiting 'talent' and using performance indicators, which provides academics and HR managers with the opportunity to select people for their institute.

Performance systems are linked with indicators such as productivity, peer review, citation indexes and internationally refereed publications (Tijssen *et al*., 2002; Van Raan, 2005; Basu, 2006). This use of performance management to assess academic talent has been hotly debated in the Western academic community (Parker and Jary, 1995; Nkomo, 2009; Özbilgin, 2009; Van den Brink & Benschop, forthcoming). For example, it is accused of placing too much emphasis on research, devaluating teaching (Kreber, 2002) and causing an overproduction of journal articles (Hearn, 2004). Other researchers point out that the criteria used to evaluate academic work cannot be fully articulated; there is always an implicit, tacit dimension (Bourdieu, 1988). We simply know too little about the factors that influence those evaluating the concept of academic talent.

The actual implementation of talent and performance management processes has hardly been studied. The few exceptions (Hiltrop, 1999; Holland *et al*., 2007; Egginton, 2010) use a rather functionalist and prescriptive approach, which focuses on cause–effect relationships, statistical testing and linear thinking (Latham *et al*., 2005). Without seeking to devalue the knowledge acquired within these studies, we adhere to McKenna *et al*. (2010) who state that an increase in paradigmatic diversity could contribute to our understanding of how academic performance and evaluation are implemented. This would involve shifting from a focus on ‘discovering best practices’ towards a more critical and reflexive research approach, which would take into account issues of power and control and the context in which the evaluation takes place (Watson, 2010). This article will therefore not enter the debate concerning the nature of recruitment and performance systems but will instead focus its discussion on how this system is integrated in the recruitment of new academic staff and on its consequences. Additionally, traditional models of performance systems have not paid enough attention to the organisational context in which evaluations occur. Janssens and Steyaert (2009) suggest a reflexive practice-based approach to HRM that takes into account multiple stakeholders, and a broader moral, social and political context.

Towards a contextual practice approach

This approach considers what has recently been termed the revival of the ‘practice turn’ in organisation studies (Schatzki *et al*., 2001; Miettinen *et al*., 2010), where the analytical focus is on organisation or work practices – *i.e.* what people say and do in their social interaction within organisations (Yanow, 2006; Nicolini, 2009). Such an approach means that concepts can evolve from lived experiences of academics rather than objectivist studies that are often detached from both worker’s and researcher’s experiences and contexts (Yanow, 2006: 1745). A broad conceptualisation of HRM practices is used that includes discursive practices articulated in policy papers or recruitment protocols as well as personal reflections on how academics recruit and select candidates. The practice perspective is therefore useful in describing the complex and dynamic interplay between the formal policies of organisations and actual daily practice in recruitment and selection. This can help us to understand how organisation members actively use, resist or alter the norms and formal policies available.

As we argue that academic recruitment and selection do not occur in a vacuum, we emphasise the need for an approach that considers the relevant (inter)organisational context. Some differences between recruitment and selection practices in academic subfields are to be expected, as each subfield exhibits features homologous to the wider social structure as well as its own specific structure and logic (Maton, 2005). For instance, subfields vary considerably with regard to the composition of students and staff, career patterns and the possibility of gaining additional funding (Becher and Trowler, 2001; Musselin, 2002). Research has also shown that academic contexts shape organisational practices and processes such as recruitment and selection. We will draw upon Becher and Trowler’s (2001) operationalisation of academic context to analyse the differences observed and select the aspects that can be related to recruitment and selection (see Table 1).

To conclude, we will contribute to the HRM literature by developing the critical practice-based approach to HRM via a study of the implementation of performance management in recruitment and selection of junior and senior academic in the Netherlands.

CASE AND METHODOLOGY

This article draws on empirical material acquired in two research projects on the recruitment and selection of academic talent in the Netherlands (Thunnissen *et al*., 2010; Van den Brink,

TABLE 1 *Overview of the characteristics of the subfields (source: Study A + B)*

	Humanities	STEM fields	Medical sciences
Prospects in the employment market outside academia	Poor	Good	Very good
Pool of candidates	Abundant number of PhD candidates, few positions	Limited number of PhD candidates, reasonable number of positions	Limited number of specialised PhD candidates
Core activities	Education and research	Research	Research, patient care
Cooperation	Individual projects/small units	Conglomerates of research groups	Multidisciplinary teams
Knowledge/epistemic culture	Subjectivity/diffuse subjects, concerned with particulars, qualities, complexity	Objectivity, concerned with universals, quantities, simplification	Objectivity, purposefulness, pragmatic, concerned with mastery of physical environment
Subfield culture	Idiocratic, pluralistic, loosely structured, personally oriented, political	Science as vocation, egalitarian, task-oriented	Practical, dominated by professional values, role-oriented
Way of recruitment	Open (64%)	Closed (73%)	Closed (77%)
Origin of professorial candidates	Internal candidates (57%)	External candidates (67%)	Internal candidates (64%)
Criteria	Multi (teaching and research)	Mono (research)	Multi (research and management) 'jack of all trades'
Leadership style	Strategic	Facilitating (transformational)	Assertive

STEM, science, technology, engineering, mathematics.

2010). The first study focused on senior academic talent: full professors; the second study on junior academic talent: PhD students, postdocs and assistant professors.

The Dutch cases are relevant for recruitment processes in a globalised academic world, as internationalisation and the new managerialism have resulted in the convergence of global academic HR practices (Slaughter and Leslie, 1997). The formal criteria used to evaluate candidates are similar to those prevailing in the Anglo-American system; bibliometrics are leading in assessing the work of academics (Van Raan, 2005; Nkomo, 2009). The job market is highly international and very competitive in most disciplines. The structure and composition of the academic career system in the Netherlands can be viewed as a pyramid. The number of lower and temporary positions is high (PhDs and other scientific staff, such as lecturers), but the number of higher permanent academic positions decreases with each rising level. There are signs that fewer students are interested in pursuing a doctorate. Factors such as the salary system and the lack of career prospects exert a large influence on their decision (van Balen & van den Besselaar, 2007). Doctoral graduates can be employed as postdoc researchers or assistant professors. Unlike the postdoc researcher, the position of assistant professor generally has a permanent contract, although the percentage of fixed-term assistant professors has risen during the last decade. The next step is a position as associate professor, and the highest position that can be reached is the level of full professor.

The most important difference with the Anglo-American system is the lack of a promotion system to progress from one rank to another. Traditionally, an upward career trajectory to the highest academic position in the Dutch system depends not only on the individual merits of an academic but also on the positions available. Each step requires a vacant position and a recruitment and selection process. Recently, universities have started to introduce the tenure track system (Fruytier and Brok, 2007). However, only a limited number of talented academics are taken on through the tenure track system, and most positions are still dependent on formal vacancies.

We initially started to explore four academic subfields: humanities, social sciences, STEM (Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics) and medical sciences, since these represent a large part of the academic spectrum (Becher and Trowler, 2001). An analysis of the predominant patterns revealed that some social sciences tend to resemble the humanities (in particular qualitative oriented studies such as anthropology, cultural studies and gender studies), whereas others tend to resemble the STEM fields (in particular quantitative studies such as psychology, sociology and economics). The social sciences were therefore regrouped accordingly so that our analysis consists of three and not four fields. Table 1 shows an overview of all contextual factors in the three different academic fields.

Study A: professorial recruitment and selection

The first research project was a study on professorial recruitment and selection in the Netherlands (Van den Brink, 2010). All 13 Dutch universities were invited to participate, but due to privacy issues and limited resources among auxiliary personnel, only seven universities agreed to cooperate. The study included an analysis of 64 interviews with committee members, and 971 appointment reports. In total, 24 women and 40 men were interviewed in their function as chairpersons, committee members and HRM advisors. They were selected on the basis of their current involvement in recruitment and selection procedures and how much experience they had in this area (Table 2).

The interviewees were asked to describe the recruitment process and highlight the arguments used by committee members to explain their choice of the nominated candidate. The

TABLE 2 *Selection of interview respondents* (source: Study A + B)

Subfields (Study A)	HRM advisor	Chair	Committee member
Humanities	2	3	8
Social Sciences	1	4	9
STEM	2	4	10
Medical Sciences	2	7	12

Subfields (Study B)	Board members	HR managers	Research directors/ supervisors	PhD/ postdocs	Tenure trackers
Humanities	1	2	2	13	17
Social Sciences (including Law)	4	5	3	9	9
STEM	2	3	2	9	5
Medical Sciences	2	2	1	5	10

STEM, science, technology, engineering, mathematics.

first author interviewed and encouraged the respondents to talk about concrete cases and incidents on the basis of anonymity, rather than in generalities.

Information from 971 appointment reports in the period 1999–2003 was used to gather background information about the number of committee members and the number of closed and open recruitment procedures. These reports contain information about the basic profile, the applicants and the final nomination, and are written by the selection committees for the university executive board, which is ultimately responsible for the appointment of candidates.

Study B: young academic talent

The second study was a project on talent management policies and practices at five Dutch universities (Thunnissen *et al.*, 2010). Five university departments were selected from five different universities representing the core academic disciplines: humanities, social sciences, STEM, medical sciences and law. Selection was based on replication criteria (Eisenhardt and Graebner, 2007) and the willingness of university executive boards and deans to participate in the study.

The study included 25 interviews with key figures around HRM and talent management such as HRM managers, members of the university executive board, research directors and deans. In addition, five focus groups were held with 30 academics who were identified by their dean as ‘rising stars’. The groups of PhD students and postdocs were between 24 and 31 years old, and the ‘tenure trackers’ between 28 and 43 years old. Men and women were almost equally represented within these groups.

Data analysis

We used qualitative content analysis (Lieblich *et al.*, 1998) to analyse the interviews, focus groups and policy documents in both studies. We first of all scanned the text and isolated the words and phrases connected to our research question: (a) what is academic talent, (b) who defines talent or excellence and (c) how are they identified. By giving open codes to different sections in the text, the first descriptive coding revealed the common patterns and themes related to these research questions, such as 'excellence', 'recruitment', 'scouts'. We then shifted to a more holistic method of content analysis, interpreting parts or categories of the text in the light of the rest of the text. In this way, we were able to find ambiguities, differences and paradoxes within and among the stories of the interviewees. In the first study, the computer programme Atlas-ti (www.atlasti.com) was used to systemise, code, compare and explore our data, since this mapping method is appropriate for interpreting large amounts of qualitative interview data.

Once we had organised and interpreted the different codes within the different subfields, we examined the differences between the subfields and interpreted these from the context. During the last phase of the analysis, we compared the two studies on academic recruitment to distinguish general patterns and themes.

RESULTS: DEFINING AND IDENTIFYING TALENT IN CONTEXT

In this section, we present the recruitment practices of junior and senior academics in three different academic fields. The disciplinary context is likely to affect the recruitment process, the criteria used and the role of performance indicators.

Humanities

Recruitment process The field of the humanities can be characterised as a 'seller's market' in which large numbers of educated professionals, abundant junior staff and a scarcity of top-level positions, result in a strong internal competition between academics and academic groups. A lack of financial resources has been the main cause of the scarcity of positions and low mobility in the upper ranks (Lubbe and Larsen, 2008). Young talents holding a PhD degree have limited employment prospects as most of them strive for an academic career. They are mostly recruited via the internal circuit, especially in the discipline of Law. There is also a relatively extensive pool of candidates for senior positions: the average number of candidates applying for a professorial position is 13–20. The majority of professorial posts are openly advertised in newspapers, websites and email networks.

According to several respondents, there is an old academic tradition in the humanities where positions are assigned to a 'crown prince'. Professors would 'nurture' their successors from the beginning of their career and teach them the informal rules of the field, such as where to publish. This being the case, the possession of good support networks and the support of influential academics are highly valued. By maintaining a support network of influential academics, candidates gather knowledge about the explicit and implicit requirements of becoming a full professor. As chairs are 'handed over' to 'crown princes and princesses', a candidate with an extensive and influential network can count on good references and support during his or her career.

Criteria In this subfield, the core activities of a scholar are research and academic education. In view of the high teaching load, teaching experience has a relatively high importance. Faculties and disciplines with large student populations need experienced lecturers, but these should also conduct research in the same subject areas as the curriculum of the department. The director of a research institute gives an example:

> "From a research perspective, I might want to fill this vacancy with a professor specialising in Italian culture, for example. However, only a limited number of students are interested in this area and so the faculty board would never approve such a nomination. Unfortunately, the director of the teaching institute exerts slightly more influence than me" (director research institute, male).

Although most respondents agree that teaching experience and pedagogic skills are important, the humanities are comparable to other fields in the dominance of research skills in the assessment of academic talent. However, research skills are not 'sacred', and are simultaneously put into perspective. For the younger talents, professors argue that they have to excel in all areas, research, teaching and administrative tasks, and that they must have a lot of experience. Due to the scarcity of positions, they mostly recruit talent that already has proven itself.

Performance indicators in relation to research are less strict and standardised.

> "We do not have A, B and C journals yet and so it is hard to identify the best journals. We are now working on such a system and when this is implemented it will be very controversial. For example, it will always be difficult to decide what is 'international', as most of the 'international' journals in our field tend to be rather nationally oriented if you take a closer look. That really is a point of controversy" (Committee Chair, male professor).

> "We have a tradition of publishing in books in other languages like Italian, German or Spanish. These publications are not included in the citation indices" (Committee Member, male professor).

The quotes illustrate that the use of bibliometrics, standard in the STEM fields and medical sciences, is far from easy in the humanities. The research criteria concerning publications in refereed international top journals and high citation scores are followed less strictly and rather more contested. As the respondents indicated, simply 'counting' publications is problematic, as there is a tradition of publishing in books, national journals and in languages other than English. The Social Sciences Citation Index, meanwhile, has been criticised by several scholars (Glänzel and Schoepflin, 1999; Archambault *et al*., 2006) because of its overvaluation of English and American publications. The use of performance indicators in the humanities is thus highly contested and debated.

Also more tacit criteria – especially in terms of personality and leadership style – play a greater role in the recruitment process. This can be related to the specific culture of the humanities that could be described as individualistic and fragmented. That is due to the individualistic orientation of the field, which consists of small units all desperate to survive rather than conglomerates of research groups. The small groups all tend to defend their own field, because they are threatened by continuous cutbacks. They argue that the combination of the scarcity of positions, the large number of potential candidates and the power of the current academic elite make the appointment process highly political. The recruitment and selection process can be compared with a tactical game of chess; one has to act strategically, and influential contacts must be fostered. When operating strategically, it is important not to step on the toes of others. Being a marked personality represents a high risk, especially for full professors; it can lead to fewer opportunities. In this individualistic and idiosyncratic culture, a communicative leadership style is valued the most highly; the chair group holder or full professor has to be able to strategically manoeuvre between autonomous groups. An authoritarian leader is not popular among humanities scholars who strongly value their autonomy by stressing their 'own decisions', 'no top-down interference' and 'freedom of research'. Leadership is ascribed to an academic on the basis of behavioural traits: a charismatic personality that can represent the group or faculty convincingly. These 'rules of behavior' are not formalised but remain highly tacit and must be learned from the current elite.

STEM fields

Recruitment process In this field, candidates are generally recruited through informal networks of scouts. The main reasons for scouting rather than using an open competition are – as the respondents argued – the high level of competition for academics, sometimes even termed 'the war for talent', and the lack of an extensive pool of candidates. In other words, the STEM fields can be described as a buyer's market in which candidates are scarce and have to be scouted. Universities even try to 'buy' academics from other national and international universities and the competition to attract and retain talented scientists is considerable.

> "Well, one is constantly monitoring – 'that person will go to that university and so we . . .'. A lot of things are taken care of informally. On the other hand, a tough competitive struggle starts when someone hears 'university X has their eye on Dr Y'. Well, then we really pull out all the stops if it is someone we really want to keep, offer that person a position. And then university X thinks: 'Well, I'll be darned' (Committee Member, male professor).

It is usually hard to persuade a renowned candidate to change position without offering very favourable conditions such as a higher salary, more staff and more equipment. The prestige of the university and the research group is therefore very important in the search for new candidates. An outstanding research reputation or extensive financial resources will increase a candidate's interest in the department. Simultaneously, when the research group's reputation or department is less sound, it will be hard to attract top scholars. At the same time, an increasing numbers of departments in this field are experimenting with the tenure track system for young academic talent, which guarantees academics a tenured position if they receive good evaluations, irrespective of whether there is a vacancy.

Criteria The core activity of full professors in the STEM fields is conducting and managing research activities. The exact sciences have teaching duties as well, but teaching skills are considered less important due to a smaller teaching load. In a large number of departments, student numbers have decreased while the number of professorial chairs has remained equal. This leads to a more one-dimensional approach for assessing the quality of candidates; the dominant criterion is research quality, which is assessed through publications, track record on obtaining grants and the international reputation of candidates. The respondents all argued that research experience and output predominate.

> "It is a matter of counting, and we essentially look at the type of publications. Good professional publications in Physical Review Letters, or articles in Nature and Science, those are the ones that count the most. In this way, you decide if someone meets the quality norm" (Committee Member, male professor).

> "The quality criterion is that you have to have an established reputation in this discipline. In practical terms this means, well, the number of publications. The quality and number of publications as well as the number of citations" (Director Research Institute, male professor).

There is a strong belief in objectivity and that research quality is easy to measure. These beliefs about the neutrality and objectivity of science make their impact felt on performance evaluations. Committee members are convinced that objective and quantifiable criteria – numbers of publications, citations and impact scores – are the best and fairest way to select candidates. The system of bibliometrics is used as the standard measure with which to assess the research qualities of academics. Interference of HR managers is not considered necessary as, in their view, it would only involve an increase in bureaucracy and even a violation of their autonomy.

> "This is not the way it works. And it all ends up in a new kind of bureaucracy in which we have to add some rules or comments about why we did this and why we didn't do that. Really, the system is self-regulating and it all works fine. Others should not endlessly interfere" (Committee Member, male professor).

Having strategic and political skills is considered of minor importance in this field. In general, a pragmatic, straightforward leadership style is valued. Research groups are small conglomerates operating within an international network of academics, which cooperate in large research groups facilitated and supervised by a project leader. Leadership and authority are ascribed to scientists with an outstanding academic reputation – in other words, an impressive track record in publications and acquisition of funds.

Medical sciences

Recruitment process In common with the STEM fields, respondents from this subfield argue that it is hard to find professorial candidates, which results in a strong competition for available candidates. The field of medical sciences is another buyer's market, with a scarcity of candidates and ample positions available. The mobility in staff positions and the opportunities to create new chairs are substantial as many forms of funding are available.

Young academic talent is mostly recruited internally during medical school or postgraduate training. HR departments support research directors in conducting so-called 'talent reviews', in which they evaluate students and staff so as to recruit and retain their most talented people. It is important to note that young academic talents cannot promote themselves. Instead, full professors argue for their people in this talent review. One respondent commented: "your relationship with your professor is crucial for your chances in the talent review, as equally his ability to present you in the best way possible". The discovery of the talent is in the hands and skills of the professors.

For professorial appointments, this subfield is characterised by a closed recruitment system in which candidates are scouted and invited to apply. A statistical analysis of the appointment reports indicated that 77 per cent of the appointed professors were recruited through a closed procedure. Scouting is not only driven by the 'search for excellence', as in the STEM fields, but because of an old academic tradition of inviting candidates personally.

> "It is an unwritten rule that you are invited for this type of job [professorial]. Extremely hypocritical, but that is how it is. So, if you are not known, nobody thinks of you. The chance that you will be the one is almost zero. [. . .] The composition of the committee is important. Your network is essential. [As a recruiter] you suppose that you're working with a company of people who know the field well. And then we say: 'John is not responding – we will call John about the vacancy'" (Committee Chair, male professor).

Other respondents from the medical field add to this by saying: 'it's common sense', 'it's a gentlemen's agreement' or 'it's just unheard of to apply for a position'. The fact that only a few specialists have the required expertise in these particular fields partly explains the low number of candidates. The high number of closed procedures indicates a 'behind the scenes' mentality and an opaque process. As far as accountability is concerned, applicants' qualifications are often presented as a conclusive argument in the report, although the comments on this point are often vaguely formulated.

Criteria In the medical sciences, professors are not only involved in research and teaching but also in the health care of patients in teaching hospitals. Since most of the professors have to communicate with their patients, candidates who speak Dutch are favoured, and so the job market has a strong national orientation.

Research quality is assessed in a highly quantitative manner similar to that of the STEM fields. Performance indicators for an outstanding research track record are the H-index and the number and quality of published articles, which is, according to the respondent, easily checked on 'PubMed'. Yet, this performance indicator is only used as a prerequisite, to filter out the best scoring academics who are then compared with each other. Several respondents from the medical discipline complain about the devaluation of bibliometrics, as 'some professors produce more than 20 articles a year, only because they put their names on the publications of PhD students or colleagues whom they have advised concerning the content of their paper. You then think, what is really original work?' Consequently, the actual selection is often based on more tacit criteria such as network connections and preferred leadership style.

The culture of the medical sciences can be described as hierarchical, professional and competitive. Cooperation is a standard concept, as different specialists must work together to answer questions and solve problems in this scientific context. As patients' lives are at stake, the hierarchical line of cooperation is clear: responsibilities are centralised, and departments need good management. A committee chair recalls her own selection interview:

> "They asked me whether I had had problems in the department that I was heading and how I had solved those situations. I had to say something about that. They also take into account whether you are a good organiser, because a department is like a small business organisation which has to run smoothly. You must have good social skills, be able to adopt a broad view and not panic too quickly. So, it's not only publications, no . . . that is clearly not enough" (Committee Chair, female professor).

The practical, professional culture goes hand-in-hand with the need for an assertive leadership style, which is shown in the remarks of the respondents: 'making difficult decisions', 'deciding the direction of the department', 'overcoming conflicts', 'ruling with an iron fist' and 'banging one's fist on the table'. Furthermore, staff members have to be confident that their head of department will be able to promote the interests of the group and resolve internal conflicts adequately. Leadership is mostly ascribed on the basis of behavioural characteristics and seniority. In other words, candidates are judged on their ability to manage the competitive and stressful practice of science and medical care.

DISCUSSION AND IMPLICATIONS

Framing the analysis in terms of HRM dilemmas is a helpful way of exploring some of the complexity of implementing talent and performance management. We present three dilemmas:

(a) transparency versus autonomy, (b) HR managers versus academic professors and (c) equality versus homogeneity. These dilemmas must be recognised, openly discussed and continuously worked on. They cannot, by definition, be resolved, but their effect and any adverse consequences can be mitigated.

Transparency versus autonomy

The first dilemma involves the desire to control and objectify recruitment versus the strong desire for academic freedom.

The broader picture of strategic human resource management revealed that academic recruitment and selection was realised in a rather amateur and ad hoc manner. HRM managers have formulated protocols and rules for academic recruitment and selection which provide steps and guidelines for the decision makers and committee members involved. However, the implementation of these protocols seems to be a different matter. At all stages of the recruitment process, we have observed actions which go against the regulations for transparency. The various academics in the process have their own agendas, which interfere with the goal of increasing the openness and formalisation of procedures. We detect a difference between HR managers who stress the importance of a more professionalised approach, and the academics who are critical or even cynical about the policies concerning transparency and performance indicators and tend to dismiss them as time-consumingly bureaucratic and a violation of their academic freedom (Anderson, 2006; Van den Brink *et al*., 2010). The academics argue that they are quite capable of evaluating the quality of candidates. They maintain that these HRM policies curtail their professional expertise and that the need for more 'accountability' restricts their freedom to select the best candidates on an academic basis. Despite the introduction of the new HR policies and performance indicators, academics keep to their own collegial system for recruiting new talent.

Although the old collegial model is preferred by the academics, it is interesting to reflect on the implications of such a system. As previously mentioned by respondents in the humanities and medical sciences, when a certain group of elite academics is responsible for the recruitment of junior and senior academics they tend to search within their own circuit. These elite academics control the flow of information and access to the vacant positions; they determine which candidates are nominated and which remain excluded (Husu, 2000). To reach the entire pool of suitable candidates and select the 'best' from this pool, the network of recruiters therefore needs to cover all fields, institutes and universities in the national and international context. These recruiters strongly believe that they have contacts across the entire field and are best qualified to identify the candidates' merits. Yet, constraints of time and resources mean that the search for candidates is in all probability based on incomplete information, and is therefore not exhaustive, with the consequence that capable candidates are excluded.

HR managers versus academic professors

In line with the above, we have seen that HR managers often lack a firm power base to influence the recruitment and selection. HRM advisors stress the lack of transparency in the procedures but often do not have the power to persuade the committees to manage the procedure differently. The HRM policies stress the importance of the presence of an HRM advisor whose role is to advise the chair of the committee concerning job profiles, the internal career trajectory, the use of evaluation criteria and so on. HRM advisors should monitor the progress of the procedure but are not official members of the committees and so have no authority. They often lack the power and inside knowledge to detect political games and favoured candidates, and to persuade the committees to manage the procedure differently.

Equality versus homogeneity

The elite academics involved in the recruitment and selection of new staff not only have the power to decide who is excellent but also to make explicit claims about their own knowledge of excellence and the talent pool. Any talent not 'seen' or 'recognised' by them is therefore not considered excellent. These judgments concerning excellence are made by academics who are already eminent, and those at the top of the various informal scientific hierarchies exercise considerable power over the standards which govern their fields. Candidates who wish to advance their careers and produce results accepted as significant contributions to knowledge must comply with the standards set by these leaders (Kanter, 1977; Gregory, 2009). Elite academics often select candidates congruent with their own personal and scientific preferences. The wish to 'clone' (Essed, 2004) oneself is understandable, and has some merit, but risks the exclusion of dissimilar people, often women, ethnic minorities or older employees. This might not serve the long-term interests of science as diverse perspectives can add value to the scientific endeavour. Committee members search for talents in their networks and invite 'appropriate' candidates. Therefore, the person selected is not necessarily the best academic, but rather the most suitable or the one most similar to the recruiters who is selected. We have seen that candidates are generally not allowed to disrupt the status quo, and yet at the same time, a strong urge for innovation is expected from them. It seems questionable whether 'more of the same' advances creative and innovative science.

CONCLUSION AND PRACTICAL IMPLICATIONS

Universities have been transforming from a collegial system, backed by an ideology that led professors to expect and to enjoy high levels of independence and autonomy, relatively free from any sense of management and accountability (Egginton, 2010), to a managerial model in which management practices are adopted from the private sector (Deem, 2001; Smeenk *et al*., 2006). It is evident that individual performance systems have entered academia and that 'excellence' and 'talent' are predominantly linked to matters such as productivity, peer review, citation indexes and international refereed publications (Tijssen *et al*., 2002; van Raan, 2005; Basu, 2006). By adopting a critical practice-based approach, this article has given insights into how performance systems are implemented and used in recruitment and selection practices. Three academic subfields (humanities, STEM fields and medicine) were compared in terms of how junior and senior academic talent are defined and identified, and by whom. It was shown that different subfields have their own way to recruit 'academic talent', as organisational practices are shaped by structural and cultural context factors. In this way, we have contributed to the contexualisation of HR policies. It was found that performance indicators such as the H-index and citation indices were widely used in most academic fields, although predominantly for the initial selection between applicants. In the next phase, where seemingly equal applicants were evaluated, the selection process became less transparent and objective. We therefore argue that relying on bibliometrics is too simplistic when reflecting on the recruitment system.

The issues that arise when implementing talent policies may also be related to the role and position held by the HR department in this regard. In many cases, this is limited to administration. HR, however, scarcely has any involvement in the recruitment, selection and supervision of talented academics. This raises the question of whether HR advisors should be more intensively involved in the application interviews, career interviews and job appraisals of talented academics. This was something raised by managers in various interviews, where it was argued that HR advisors could provide added value because they focus more effectively on other qualities in the academics than those that are purely subject-related. The HR advisor also has a better understanding of the opportunities for development that the organisation can offer, which means that the faculty's policy on talented young academics can be communicated more directly. They can prepare interviews in consultation with managers, chair the interviewing panel and compile the report on these interviews. This would give them a more instrumental role in recruitment policy, comparable with that of many HRM advisors in R&D facilities or other public sector bodies (Perkins and White, 2010).

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